sex shops in West Berlin). Over time, Honecker amassed a vast collection – one that the German media covered extensively at the time, particularly titles such as Lady Diamond and The Black Nymphomaniac, starring Ajita Wilson playing a reporter and nymphomaniac infiltrating a sex gang.15 Honecker owned two copies of Black Emanuelle, which according to Lexikon des Erotic Films, tells the story of a dark-skinned photographer 'who is screwed over by a white couple and then by a whole hockey team'. Snugly hidden in the basement of his vacation home in Libbesicke See, Der Spiegel magazine later reported, Honecker amassed a total of 4,864 videos at a cost of DM1.3million.16

Also, it is true that during periods of strained marital tension, Erich Honecker could be inventive. On one occasion during the summer of 1981, to prevent Margot from accompanying him on a state visit to Japan, he arranged for her to be invited to Yugoslavia (in the capacity of minister of education). It worked: Margot flew to Belgrade and Erich arrived in Tokyo, on what turned out to be a trip full of tragic-comic moments and gaffes. Bodyguard Lothar Herzog never forgot how Horst Bries, the GDR ambassador to Japan, was so excited after leaving an audience at the Imperial Palace with Emperor Hirohito that he accidentally put on Honecker's shoes, even though they were far too small. 'For better or for worse,' Herzog recounted, 'the head of the State Council then had to slip into Bries' worn-out shoes'.17 On another occasion, he looked awkward when receiving an honorary doctorate from a Japanese university and showed himself ill-adapted to protocol when refusing to wear formal tails. For him, such attire was the 'epitome of bourgeois decadence'. In the end, he was received by Hirohito wearing a dark suit and chestnut coloured tie.

Within the period of eighteen years, Brezhnev had taken a relatively robust Soviet economy and transformed it into one of stagnation and lower industrial production. Compounding matters, the debt-free country he usurped from Khrushchev in 1964 had amassed over U$20 billion worth of hard currency debt. Herb Meyer, a US specialist in economic warfare and the right-hand man of CIA boss William Casey, reported that the Soviet Union had sold 240 tons of gold on the world market in 1981, compared to only 90 tons in 1980 – an unmistakable sign that the USSR was in great trouble.